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Leviticus

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Leviticus

A. Theme and background:

1. Leviticus takes its name from the Septuagint (commonly abbreviated LXX) which was a Greek translation from the Hebrew by 70 Hebrew scholars in Alexandria, Egypt about 100 BC. The LXX entitled the book *Leueitikon* meaning the “Book of the Levites” who because of their faithfulness in standing with Moses, became priests, administering the laws of God, and leading worship. The book can seem tedious as it deals with many laws, rules and regulations given by God to Moses teaching the Levites and the people about offerings, sacrifices, Holy Days, celebrations, feasts and morality. There is no geographical movement of Israel in the book of Leviticus; they remain at the foot of Mt. Sinai. Writers of the New Testament quote from the book of Leviticus over 15 times.
2. A key theme running throughout Leviticus is the Holiness of God. Holiness is mentioned 152 times in Leviticus more than any other book in the Bible. God’s intention is that His people should be holy as He is holy (Leviticus 19:1-2) meaning separation from sin and the corruption that is in the world. But as sinful people, we need cleansing from our sin. For this reason, the book opens with sacrifices and offerings which point to Jesus our Savior who shed His blood on the Cross for our redemption and forgiveness.
3. For the Christian, we should always bear in mind that the Old Testament laws represent the Old Covenant and since Pentecost (Acts chapter 2), we are not bound by them but are under the New Covenant. However, they should point us to the Holy God who is approached by His way not ours. The law is useful for us to realize our sinfulness before God and as a means of showing our need for repentance and reconciliation to Him. As the Apostle Paul says, “The law is good if one uses it properly” (1 Timothy 1:8).

B. Laws pertaining to the five offerings. Some commentators see the first three offerings as related to the person of Christ. The last two are seen as related to the work of Christ on the Cross.

1. The Burnt offering or related to Christ as our substitute (1:1-17)
2. The Grain offering related to the loveliness of Christ (2:1-16)
3. The Fellowship offering or Christ as our peace offering (3:1-17)

4. The Sin offering related to our sin nature (4:1-35)
5. The Trespass offering for sin as an act (5:1-19)
6. Law of the offerings (Leviticus 6 and 7)

C. The Priesthood (8:1-10:20) In the Old Testament, the tribe of Levi were the priests who interceded for the people to God. There was a veil in the temple that separated the Holy of Holies where God dwelt from the rest of the temple where man dwelt. Only the High Priest could enter the Holy of Holies and only once a year to offer sacrifice for the sins of the people (Leviticus 16). At the moment Jesus cried out "It is finished" meaning His work of salvation was complete and He died, the veil was torn from top to bottom indicating that Jesus's work of salvation was complete. Now we as New Testament believers are all priests and have full access to God (Matthew 27:50-51).

1. Consecration of Aaron and his sons as priests (8:1-36)
2. Ministry of the priests (9:1-24)
3. Two of Aaron's sons, Nadab and Abihu offered unauthorized fire and are killed by the Lord (10:1-2).

D. Holiness in daily life (chapters 11-22).

1. Prescriptions pertaining to clean and unclean food (11:1-46)
2. Purification after childbirth (12:1-8)
3. Regulations pertaining to skin disease and mold and their cleansing (Chapters 13 and 14)
4. Bodily discharges and instructions on cleansing (15:1-33)
5. The Day of Atonement (Chapter 16). Aaron was instructed to take two goats and slaughter one as a sin offering for himself and the people. He then was to lay both hands on the live goat, called the scape goat (Azazel), while confessing all the sins and rebellion of the people. The scape goat was then led into the wilderness and released. The scapegoat prefigures Christ who had no sin being made sin for us so that we might become the righteousness of God (2 Corinthians 5:21). Our sins were laid upon Christ on the Cross. He was crucified outside the city like the scape goat which was taken outside the camp (Hebrews 13:12). Like the scapegoat, he bore the sins of many and made intercession for the transgressors (Isaiah 53:12). Moses is instructed that the Day of Atonement is to be commemorated once a year as a lasting ordinance (16:34).

6. Matters pertaining to blood (17:1-16). "For the life of a creature is in the blood, and I have given it to you to make atonement for yourselves on the altar; it is the blood that makes atonement for one's life" (17:11). Forgiveness of sin requires the shedding of blood resulting in death (Hebrews 9:22). As Paul tells us "the wages of sin is death" (Romans 6:23). That is why Jesus had to shed His blood on the Cross for the forgiveness of our sins. Blood was set apart by God for the forgiveness of sin. For this reason, the Israelites were prohibited from eating blood (17:12).
7. Laws pertaining to sexual relations (Chapter 18)
8. Various laws regarding purity towards God and one another (Chapter 19)
9. Various laws concerning sins of idolatry, sexual relations and witchcraft (Chapter 20). The penalty for many of these sins including adultery and homosexuality was death. God's intention again was that His people were to be holy and to be set apart from the nations into which they were going (20:26). "Keep all my decrees and laws and follow them, so that the land where I am bringing you to live may not vomit you out. You must not live according to the customs of the nations I am going to drive out before you. Because they did all these things, I abhorred them" (20:22-23).
10. Laws for the priests (Chapters 21 and 22).
11. The appointed festivals (Chapter 23).
12. Laws pertaining to olive oil and bread in the tabernacle, dealing with a blasphemer, murder and an eye for an eye and tooth for a tooth (Chapter 24).
13. Laws regarding the Sabbath year, the year of Jubilee, the poor and slavery (Chapter 25). Every seventh year, the land was to have rest to revitalize it. Every 50th year there was to be a release from debt and bondage.
14. Blessing or cursing for obeying or disobeying God's laws (Chapter 26).
15. Laws pertaining to free will offerings (Chapter 27).

E. Leviticus concludes with "These are the commands the LORD gave Moses at Mount Sinai for the Israelites" (27:34).

F. Discussion questions, application and passing it on.

1. Many Christians do not see how the Old Testament and particularly Leviticus is relevant to us today. Can you explain the gospel in Leviticus?

2. The temple veil was torn top to bottom giving us full access to God through the accomplished work of Christ. We are no longer reliant upon priests to intercede for us. Do you approach God frequently and in what way?
3. Many people view the God presented in the Old Testament as an angry and vindictive God. Could you explain God's desire that His people be holy as He is holy and the proper use of the law?
4. How would you explain why God killed Nadab and Abihu?
5. The scape goat represents Christ who suffered outside "the camp". Hebrews instructs us "Let us, then, go to him outside the camp, bearing the disgrace he bore. For here we do not have an enduring city, but we are looking for the city that is to come". To go outside the camp in these days means that we may hold biblical principles which run counter to modern culture. This means such things as sexual sin of all kinds, transgenderism, improper views of race or obeying God rather than man. Are you prepared to bear the disgrace that holding biblical principles may bring?
6. Are you bound by modern culture or are you "looking for the city that is to come?"

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)

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In Christ,

The JesusOnline Ministries Team

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